

FREE WHITE PAPER

# Running the Day, From First Call to Close

A simple routine for the counter, the bays and the cash drawer, so everyone knows where every car stands.

For independent auto repair shops with ten technicians or fewer.

XSite Auto xsiteauto.com

BEFORE YOU START

# Calm shops aren't less busy.

They run the same routine every day, so nobody has to remember where things stand. The phone gets answered, cars move through the bays in order, customers get called before they call you, and the money is counted before anyone goes home.

This white paper walks through a working day in ten stages, from the fifteen minutes before you open to the ten-minute close. Each stage has a goal, the steps, a script where words matter, the common mistakes, and one number to track.

It works with a whiteboard and a clipboard. Where a tool makes a stage easier, we point out how XSite Auto handles it, but the routine comes first. At the back you'll find a sample day, who does what in shops of different sizes, and two printable sheets: a check-in form and an end-of-day close.


01 **Before the doors open**
15 minutes before opening

02 **The phone and online bookings**
All day

03 **Check-in at the counter**
Two minutes a car

04 **Diagnosis and the quote**
First hour of each job

05 **Getting approval**
Within an hour of the quote

06 **Parts**
As soon as work is approved

07 **In the bay**
All day

08 **Pickup**
When the car is ready

09 **Getting paid**
At pickup

10 **The ten-minute close**
Last ten minutes

STAGE 1 OF 10 · 15 MINUTES BEFORE OPENING

# Before the doors open

The first fifteen minutes set the pace for the whole day. Shops that start by looking at the board together spend less of the afternoon putting out fires.

**Goal:** Everyone knows what's on today, who's doing it, and what could hold it up.

## THE STEPS

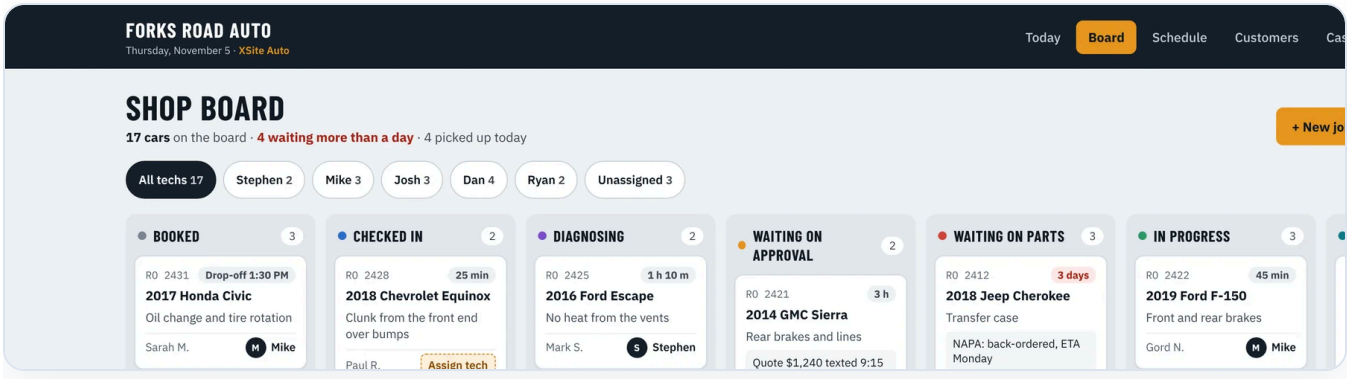
1. Walk through today's board: every car booked, carried over from yesterday or waiting on something.
2. Match jobs to technicians, and check nobody is booked for more hours than they have.
3. Check that parts for the first jobs have arrived, and chase anything that hasn't.
4. Note which cars are waiting on an approval or a part, and who is following up.
5. Agree who answers the phone this morning.

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Starting work before anyone has looked at the whole day.
- Finding out at 10 am that the part for the 8 am job isn't here.

TRACK THIS

**First job started on time,**
most mornings.



The shop board: every car in one column by stage.

**In XSite Auto:** The Today screen shows online requests, money owing and every car on the board, and the shop board lays out each stage at a glance.

STAGE 2 OF 10 · ALL DAY

# The phone and online bookings

A booking taken in a hurry on the phone creates work later: a call back for the vehicle, a guess at how long it takes, a customer who shows up on the wrong day.

**Goal: Every booking has the same details, and goes on the schedule against real technician hours.**

## THE STEPS

1. Take the same details every time: name, a mobile number that takes texts, email, year, make and model, and the concern in the customer's own words.
2. Ask whether they'll wait or drop it off, and when they need it back.
3. Book against hours, not slots. Check the technician who does that work is in that day.
4. Read the booking back: day, time, what you're looking at, and your diagnostic fee if it applies.
5. Give customers a way to book online, so after-hours customers don't have to wait until you open.

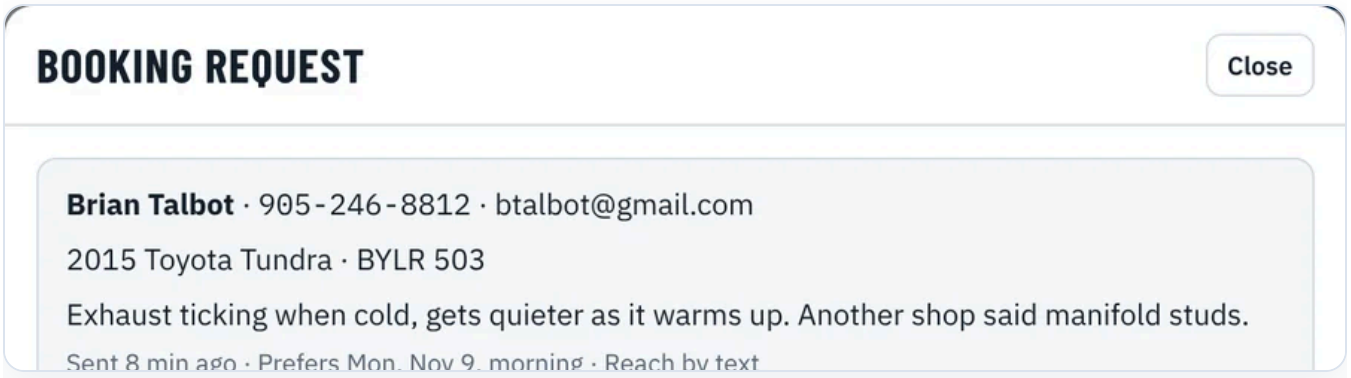
> *"So that's Thursday at 8, the 2019 Tundra, for a noise from the front when braking. If we need to look further, our diagnostic is [amount], and we'll call you before doing anything else."*

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Writing "brakes" when the customer said "grinding noise on the left when it's cold".
- Booking a four-hour job into a one-hour gap.

TRACK THIS

**Bookings with complete details,**
checked at the end of each day.




An online booking arrives with the vehicle and the concern already filled in.

**In XSite Auto:** Online bookings and walk-in check-ins drop straight onto your schedule with the customer's details and concern.

STAGE 3 OF 10 · TWO MINUTES A CAR

# Check-in at the counter

Most arguments at pickup start at drop-off: a concern that wasn't written down clearly, a phone number that's wrong, or no agreement on what you could go ahead with.

**Goal:** **Before the keys leave the counter, you know what to fix, how to reach the owner, and what you can approve.**

## THE STEPS

1. Confirm the phone number and email, and ask how they want to be reached: call, text or email.
2. Record the mileage and repeat the concern back in their words.
3. Ask how much you can go ahead on without calling, and write it down.
4. Point out any existing damage on a quick walk-around.
5. Tag the keys and put the car on the board.

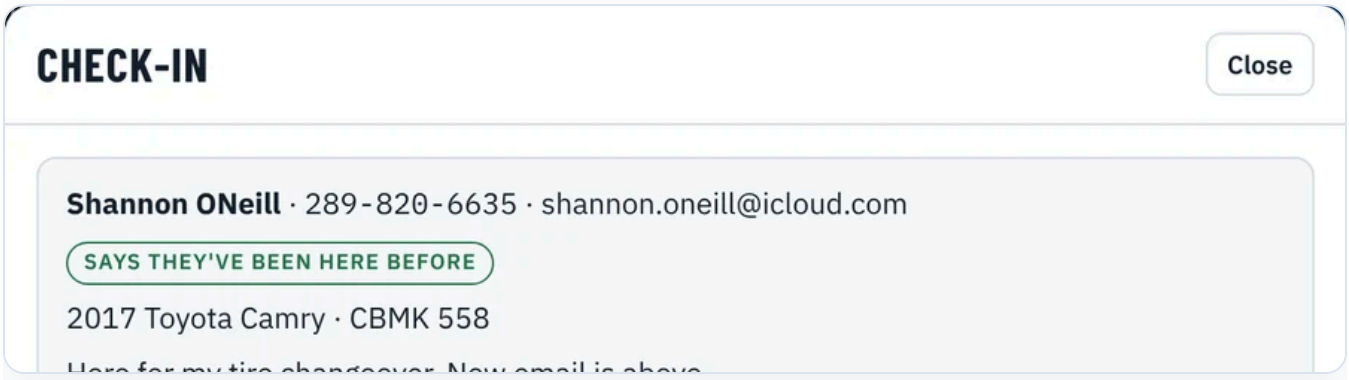
> *"If we find anything else, how much are you comfortable with us going ahead on without calling you first?"*

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Skipping the check-in for regulars because "we know them".
- No approval limit, so every small extra waits for a callback.

TRACK THIS

**Cars checked in with an approval limit,**
every day.




Walk-ins scan a QR code at the counter and fill in their own details.

**In XSite Auto:** Walk-ins scan a QR code and enter their own details and vehicle, and returning customers are matched to their record.

STAGE 4 OF 10 · FIRST HOUR OF EACH JOB

# Diagnosis and the quote

Diagnosis is where a lot of a shop's day disappears. Without a time limit and a clear way to present what was found, it turns into free hours and confused customers.

**Goal:** **Find the problem in a set time, then give a clear quote sorted by what matters most.**

## THE STEPS

1. Time-box diagnosis. If it isn't found in the first block, stop and call the customer before going further.
2. Write down what was found, with a photo when it helps the customer understand.
3. Build the full quote before calling: parts, labour, shop supplies and tax.
4. Sort recommendations into three groups: needed now for safety, needed soon, and can wait.
5. Note the price of everything you recommend, including what can wait.

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Calling the customer before the quote is finished, then calling back with a different number.
- Mixing urgent safety work with nice-to-have items in one long list.

TRACK THIS

**Diagnoses finished within the first block,**
out of all diagnoses each week.




One repair order with the concern, work done, labour and parts.

**In XSite Auto:** The repair order holds the concern, the work, labour and parts in one place, and the board tracks cars that are diagnosing.

STAGE 5 OF 10 · WITHIN AN HOUR OF THE QUOTE

# Getting approval

A car waiting for approval blocks a bay and a technician. The faster you get an answer, the more of the day stays on schedule.

**Goal:** **A clear yes or no, quickly, with a record of exactly what was approved.**

## THE STEPS

1. Call first, using the contact method the customer chose at check-in.
2. Send the quote in writing by text or email straight after the call, with a photo if it helps.
3. Record who approved, the amount, and the time. Write down anything declined, with its price.
4. Make one person responsible for approvals, and have them check every waiting car at least twice a day.
5. If a car will wait more than an hour, move it off the hoist.

> *"We found what's causing the noise. The front pads and rotors are worn through, which is a safety item. It's [amount] all in, and we can have it done by 3. Would you like us to go ahead?"*

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Leaving a voicemail and waiting.
- Approvals given verbally to whoever answered the phone, with nothing written down.

TRACK THIS

**Cars waiting more than four hours**

for an approval, counted each day.

**In XSite Auto:** The board has a "waiting on approval" column and flags cars that have waited more than a day.

STAGE 6 OF 10 · AS SOON AS WORK IS APPROVED

# Parts

Parts problems rarely look like money problems. They look like a technician waiting, a car sitting overnight, or a supplier statement that doesn't make sense.

**Goal: The right parts arrive when the technician needs them, and every part bought ends up on an invoice or back with the supplier.**

## THE STEPS

1. Order as soon as the job is approved, and write the expected arrival time on the job.
2. Tell the customer the same day if parts will delay the job.
3. When parts arrive, check them against the order before the technician starts.
4. Put returns and cores on a shelf with a log: date, part and credit owed.
5. Price parts from a written guide, not by feel.

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Ordering parts before the job is approved, and getting stuck with them.
- Cores piling up in the corner with no record.

TRACK THIS

**Jobs delayed by parts,**
and the value of open returns and cores.

**In XSite Auto:** The parts arrival time sits on the job card on the board, so everyone can see what a car is waiting for.

STAGE 7 OF 10 · ALL DAY

# In the bay

When nobody knows where a car is up to, the counter interrupts the bays to ask, customers get vague answers, and finished cars sit in the lot.

**Goal:** **Each technician works one job at a time, and the board always shows where every car stands.**

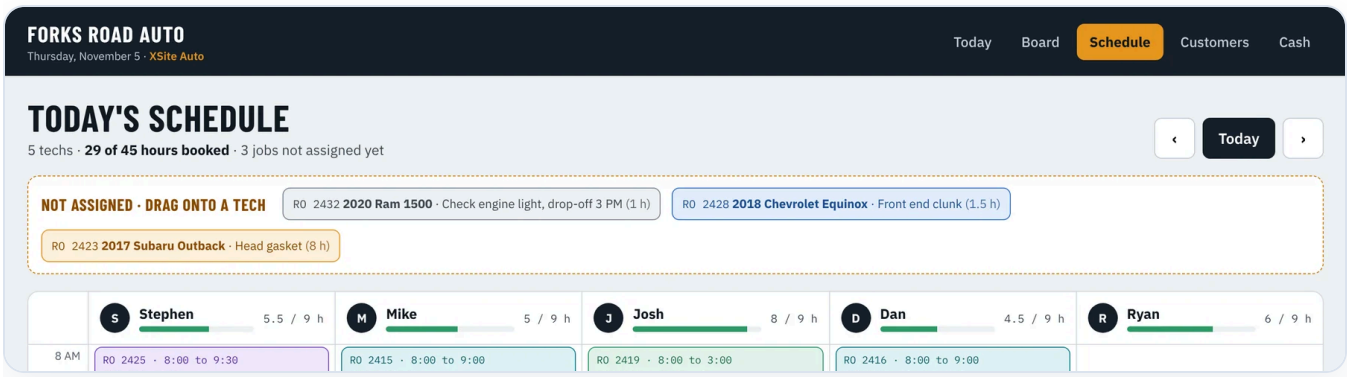
## THE STEPS

1. One active job per technician. When it's finished, move it on the board before starting the next.
2. Write every task on the repair order, even the ones you decide not to charge for.
3. Finish every job with a short final check and a road test, signed by the technician.
4. Have a second person check brakes, steering and wheels on any job that touched them.
5. When a car is ready, move it to ready straight away so the counter can call the customer.

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Technicians switching between three cars at once.
- A finished car sitting for two hours because nobody told the counter.

**TRACK THIS** **Hours billed ÷ hours worked,** for each technician, each week.




The day schedule: one column per technician, with hours booked against hours available.

**In XSite Auto:** The day schedule shows each technician's jobs and hours, and a job moves from booked to ready to picked up with one tap.

STAGE 8 OF 10 · WHEN THE CAR IS READY

# Pickup

Pickup is the moment the customer decides whether they'll come back and whether they'll recommend you. A few minutes here are worth more than any advertising.

**Goal: The customer arrives to an invoice that's ready, understands what was done, and knows what to plan for next.**

## THE STEPS

1. Call or text as soon as the car is ready, with the total.
2. Have the invoice ready before they walk in.
3. Walk through what was done and anything recommended for later, with prices.
4. Ask happy customers for a review while they're at the counter, and send them the link.
5. Return the keys after payment.

> *"Everything went well. We did the front brakes and the rotors. The rear brakes have some life left, probably until spring. Would you mind leaving us a quick review? I'll text you the link."*

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Calling the customer at 5:55 to say the car is ready.
- Handing over keys and an invoice without a word about the work.

TRACK THIS

**Reviews asked for,**

each day.

STAGE 9 OF 10 · AT PICKUP

# Getting paid

Unpaid balances are the easiest money to lose and the most awkward to recover. A clear habit at the counter avoids almost all of them.

**Goal:** **Every car leaves paid, or on an account that's written down with a due date.**

## THE STEPS

1. Post a simple payment policy at the counter: payment is due at pickup.
2. Take payment before the keys go back. Make it easy, with every common payment type.
3. If it goes on an account, write down the amount, the terms and the due date.
4. Keep one list of everyone who owes you, and look at it every Monday.
5. Follow up at 7 days and again at 30.

## COMMON MISTAKES

- "Pay me next time" for regulars, with nothing written down.
- Finding an old balance months later.

TRACK THIS

**Total owed, and the oldest balance,**
checked every Monday.

**In XSite Auto:** Payments of every type are recorded on the job, and balances owing show on the Today screen and on each customer.

STAGE 10 OF 10 · LAST TEN MINUTES

# The ten-minute close

The close is the habit that holds the others together. Ten minutes at the end of the day saves hours at the end of the month.

**Goal:** **The day's money is counted, the paperwork matches, and tomorrow is ready.**

## THE STEPS

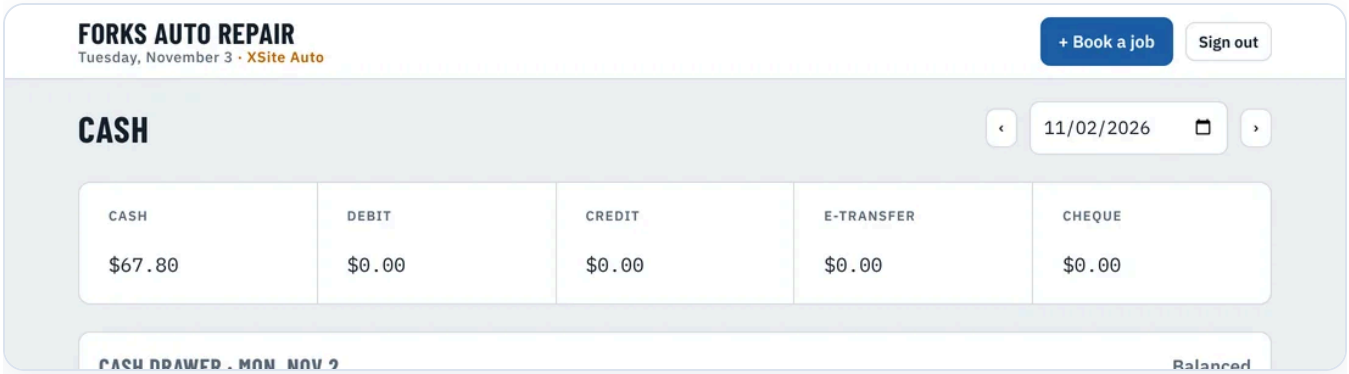
1. Count the drawer and total the day's payments by type. Write down any over or short amount.
2. Read through today's repair orders for work done that isn't billed.
3. Check who still owes you and who needs a call tomorrow.
4. Look at tomorrow's board: first jobs, technicians on shift, parts due.
5. Bring the day into QuickBooks, daily or at least weekly.

## COMMON MISTAKES

- Leaving the count for the morning.
- Letting the bookkeeping pile up until month end.

**TRACK THIS**

**Over or short,**
every day, written down.




Daily totals by payment type and a drawer count at close.

**In XSite Auto:** The cash screen shows totals by payment type, money paid out, the count at close and over or short, with an export for QuickBooks.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

# A day at a glance

Here's how the routine can fit into a normal day. Move the times to suit your hours. What matters is that each check happens at the same time every day.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **7:45** | **Morning look at the board** | Today's jobs, technicians, parts and anything carried over. |
| **8:00** | **Drop-offs and check-in** | Two-minute check-in for every car, with an approval limit. |
| **9:30** | **First quotes out** | Diagnoses from the morning drop-offs become written quotes. |
| **10:30** | **Approval check** | Every waiting car followed up. Parts ordered for approved jobs. |
| **12:00** | **Lunch cover** | Someone is on the phone. Missed calls returned within 15 minutes. |
| **2:00** | **Approval check** | Second sweep of waiting cars. Parts ETAs updated on the board. |
| **3:30** | **Ready calls** | Customers called as cars finish, with the total, so pickup isn't a rush. |
| **5:00** | **Pickups** | Invoices ready, work explained, reviews asked for, payment taken. |
| **5:30** | **The ten-minute close** | Drawer, repair orders, balances owing and tomorrow's board. |

## Who does what

The routine is the same at every size. What changes is who does each part.

### Just you

- Let online booking take the calls you can't.
- Do approvals and ready calls at set times, not between every job.
- Keep the close to ten minutes, every day.

### 2 to 4 people

- One person owns the phone and the counter at the busiest times.
- The owner does the morning look and the close.
- One person is responsible for approvals.

### 5 to 10 people

- A service writer runs the counter, quotes and approvals.
- A lead technician assigns jobs and checks final work.
- The owner reviews the numbers weekly.

PRINTABLE

# Check-in sheet

Two minutes with this sheet at drop-off prevents most arguments at pickup.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Customer name** | |
| **Mobile (takes texts)** | |
| **Email** | |
| **Best way to reach** | Call ☐ Text ☐ Email ☐ |
| **Year, make, model** | |
| **Plate and mileage** | |
| **Concern, in their words** | |
| **OK to go ahead up to** | $ |
| **Waiting or dropping off** | Waiting ☐ Drop-off ☐ Needed back by: |
| **Existing damage noted** | |
| **Diagnostic fee explained** | Yes ☐ |
| **Key tag number** | |
| **Checked in by** | |

PRINTABLE

# End-of-day close

Ten minutes, the same time every day. Date: _____ Closed by: _____

- [ ] Drawer counted
  Cash $_____ Debit $_____ Credit $_____ E-transfer $_____ Over or short $_____
- [ ] Money paid out of the drawer recorded, with receipts
- [ ] Today's repair orders read through for work done that isn't billed
- [ ] Declined work written on each repair order, with prices
- [ ] Balances owing checked
  Calls needed tomorrow: _____
- [ ] Cars waiting on approval or parts noted for the morning
- [ ] Tomorrow's board checked: first jobs, technicians on shift, parts due
- [ ] Missed calls from today all returned
- [ ] Review requests sent to today's happy customers
- [ ] Day brought into QuickBooks (or set aside for the weekly entry)

# The routine, without the paperwork

XSite Auto puts online booking, walk-in check-in, the shop board, technician schedules, repair orders, payments and the cash drawer in one place, built for shops with ten technicians or fewer. Bring your customers over from QuickBooks in minutes.

**$139 CAD a month, plus tax** after a free 14-day trial, with no credit card needed and no contract. Done-for-you setup is optional ($695 CAD, one time).

**Start a free trial** **Book a 15-minute demo**

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